

Some words in the English language have similar sounds and they might have the same pronunciation or same spelling. Such words are often confused with each other and are then, wrongfully used. Similarly, there are some phrases which are used incorrectly. Because of the complex nature of the English language and the cultural differences across the world, these phrases are commonly misused.

## ➔ Homophones

Look at these sentences and pay attention to the highlighted words.

Anshu is **deer** to me.

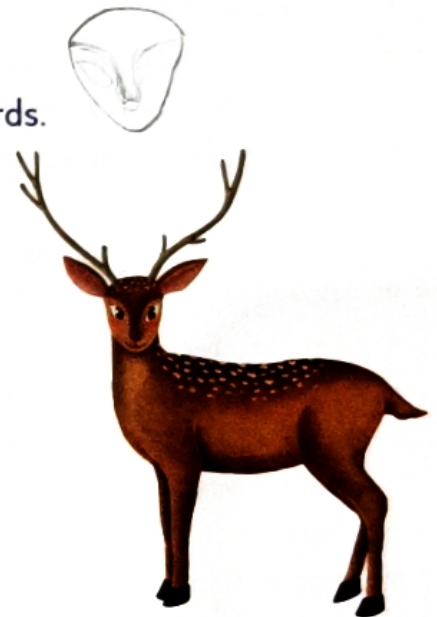
I saw a **dear** in the zoo.

Both of these highlighted words sound the same but have different meanings and spellings. Such words are called **homophones**. Because of their pronunciation, they are wrongfully used in these sentences and the meaning of the sentence is illogical. The correct sentences are:

Anshu is **dear** to me.

I saw many **deer** in the zoo.

Now, the homophones are correctly used and the sentences make sense.



**Homophones** are words that have similar pronunciations but different meanings and different spellings. They are often confused because they have somewhat similar pronunciations.

Here's a list of some common homophones and how they are used in a sentence.

| Homophones                                                                                                                                                        | Examples                                                                                                                                              |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>advice: noun; an idea or opinion that someone gives to help you decide</li> <li>advise: verb; to give advice to</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>He did not listen to his father's <b>advice</b>.</li> <li>My mother <b>advised</b> me to work hard.</li> </ul> |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>bear: noun, an animal</li> <li>bare: uncovered</li> </ul>                                                                  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>I saw a <b>bear</b> in the zoo.</li> <li>Do not walk <b>bare</b> feet.</li> </ul>                              |



| Homophones                                                                                                                                                                                             | Examples                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>cite: quote</li> <li>site: location</li> <li>complement: adding something to improve or make it more attractive</li> <li>compliment: praise, respect</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Pramod <b>cited</b> many examples.</li> <li>This is the <b>site</b> for our new house.</li> <li>The dishes on the menu <b>complement</b> each other perfectly.</li> <li>Everyone <b>complimented</b> him on his achievement.</li> </ul> |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>check: examine</li> <li>cheque: bank order</li> <li>die: to stop living</li> <li>dye: to colour</li> </ul>                                                      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li><b>Check</b> your answer.</li> <li>He gave me a <b>cheque</b> for ₹10,000.</li> <li>At least six people <b>died</b> in the accident.</li> <li>I will <b>dye</b> my hair black.</li> </ul>                                               |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>brake: device to stop the vehicle</li> <li>break: to split</li> </ul>                                                                                           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>My cycle has no <b>brakes</b>.</li> <li>Don't <b>break</b> my toy.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                           |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>fair: an exhibition of goods</li> <li>fare: money paid for the journey</li> <li>feet: plural of the word, foot</li> <li>feat: tricks</li> </ul>                 | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>I went to see the trade <b>fair</b>.</li> <li>What is the bus <b>fare</b> from Delhi to Jaipur?</li> <li>Football is played with <b>feet</b>.</li> <li>The juggler showed many <b>feats</b>.</li> </ul>                                 |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>flour: finely ground grain</li> <li>flower: blossom of a plant</li> <li>heal: to recover</li> <li>heel: the hind part of the foot</li> </ul>                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Chapatis are made from wheat <b>flour</b>.</li> <li>Tulip is a beautiful <b>flower</b>.</li> <li>The wound will soon <b>heal</b> up.</li> <li>She hurt her <b>heel</b>.</li> </ul>                                                      |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>lose: to be unable to find something/somebody</li> <li>loose: not tight</li> </ul>                                                                              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>I have <b>lost</b> the car keys.</li> <li>He was wearing a <b>loose</b> shirt.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                               |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>not: indicating negative</li> <li>knot: fastening</li> </ul>                                                                                                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Ghosts are <b>not</b> real.</li> <li>Tie the <b>knot</b>.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>stationary: fix in a place</li> <li>stationery: writing material</li> </ul>                                                                                     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>I remained <b>stationary</b>.</li> <li>I need some <b>stationery</b>.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                        |

A

**Fill in the blanks with the correct words in the brackets.**

- She gave him a piece of her mind. (peace/piece)
- He's the heir to the throne. (hair/heir)
- Do you think I can break that stick in half? (break/brake)
- What do you think an eagle prey on? (prey/pray)
- I could not hear what he said. (here/hair/hear)
- Why do you look like a deer caught in headlights? (deer/dear)
- I forgot to bring my stationery kit to school today. (stationary/stationery)
- These pants are loose. (loose/lose)



## Homonyms

Look at these sentences and pay attention to the words in blue.

The girl's grip on the **bat** tightened.

Careful, there's a **bat** hanging on the tree.

In both of these sentences, the meaning of the word **bat** is completely different. Even though it's written and pronounced the same way, the meaning changes depending on the context it is used in. Such words are called **homonyms**.

**Homonyms** are words that are spelt and pronounced in the same manner but have different meanings. There might be more than two meanings of the same word depending on the context.

Here's a list of some common homonyms, their different meanings and how they are used in a sentence.

| Words | Meaning                                                                                                                                                                                          | Examples                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| bat   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• a piece of wood with a handle, used in sports like cricket and baseball</li><li>• an animal with wings that flies and feeds at night</li></ul>           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• The girl's grip on the <b>bat</b> tightened.</li><li>• <b>Bats</b> are the only flying mammal.</li></ul>                               |
| band  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• a small group of musicians who play popular music together</li><li>• a thin flat piece or circle of any material that is put around things</li></ul>     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• The <b>band</b> is soon going on a world tour.</li><li>• They give <b>bands</b> to everyone for verification.</li></ul>                |
| mean  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• to have something as a meaning in the same or another language</li><li>• unkind, for example by not letting somebody have or do something</li></ul>      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• What is the <b>meaning</b> of that word?</li><li>• You should not be <b>mean</b> to people.</li></ul>                                  |
| ring  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• a piece of jewellery that you wear on your finger</li><li>• the sound that a bell makes</li></ul>                                                        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Do you like this <b>ring</b>?</li><li>• The phone is <b>ringing</b>.</li></ul>                                                         |
| match | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• a sports event where people or teams compete against each other</li><li>• a person or thing that combines well with somebody or something else</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• The football <b>match</b> has been postponed.</li><li>• I think that the carpet <b>matches</b> perfectly with the furniture.</li></ul> |



| Words | Meaning                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Examples                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| rose  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>a flower</li> <li>past tense of the verb, rise</li> </ul>                                                                                                                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>The garden was filled with pink <b>roses</b>.</li> <li>The profit <b>rose</b> by 14 per cent.</li> </ul>                                                                  |
| well  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>in a good, right or acceptable way</li> <li>a deep hole in the ground from which people obtain water</li> </ul>                                                              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>They have been working <b>well</b> together.</li> <li>The <b>well</b> behind the fort is haunted!</li> </ul>                                                              |
| saw   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>a tool that has a long blade</li> <li>past tense of the verb, see</li> </ul>                                                                                                 | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>You can cut this piece of wood by using a <b>saw</b>.</li> <li>I <b>saw</b> you outside the café last Saturday.</li> </ul>                                                |
| trip  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>a journey to a place and back again, especially a short one for pleasure or a particular purpose</li> <li>to catch your foot on something and fall or almost fall</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>I want to take a <b>trip</b> to the mountains.</li> <li>I <b>tripped</b> over the carpet and almost fell.</li> </ul>                                                      |
| duck  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>a bird</li> <li>to move your head or body downwards to avoid being hit or seen</li> </ul>                                                                                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>A <b>duck</b> came over to us when we were sitting by the edge of the lake.</li> <li>I barely managed to <b>duck</b> before the ball went flying over my head.</li> </ul> |

**B** Below are a few more homonyms. Look for two of their meanings in the dictionary and make a sentence for each.

- In Fair Book
- |                                                 |          |          |
|-------------------------------------------------|----------|----------|
| 1. bark <i>dog barking</i>                      | 2. pound | 3. drop  |
| 4. die                                          | 5. right | 6. point |
| 7. current <i>the current video is about it</i> | 8. tire  |          |



## Suffixes

**Suffixes** are letters or groups of letters added at the end of words that make new words.

**Examples:** Upon adding the suffix **-able** to the root word **comfort**, the new word would be **comfortable**.

comfort + -able = comfortable

Similarly, pain + -less = painless

bad + -ly = badly

Here is a list of some common suffixes and new words that are made with them.



| Suffix | Words                                                                                   |
|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| -able  | admirable, agreeable, approachable, avoidable, believable, breakable, comfortable       |
| -en    | blacken, brighten, cheapen, dampen, darken, fatten, flatten, freshen, gladden           |
| -ful   | armful, careful, cheerful, colourful, delightful, fearful, forgetful, helpful, hopeful  |
| -ion   | action, attraction, celebration, collection, collision, communication, confusion        |
| -ly    | badly, bravely, brightly, cleverly, fairly, foolishly, freely, gladly, greatly, happily |
| -less  | fruitless, priceless, speechless, sleepless, hapless, senseless, limitless, cordless    |
| -er    | catcher, commander, dancer, defender, designer, dodger, driver, dryer, explorer         |

## Rules of Adding Suffixes

There are certain rules which need to be followed while adding suffixes to a root word.

1. When adding the suffixes **-ness** and **-ly** to a word, the spelling of the word does not change.

**Examples:** kind + **-ness** = kindness      love + **-ly** = lovely

### Stay Ahead



The exception to the rule above is that when the suffixes **-ness** and **-ly** are added to the words ending with **-y**, the **-y** is changed to **-i** before adding the suffix.

**Examples:** ready + **-ly** = readily      giddy + **-ness** = giddiness

2. When a word ends with **-y** and has a vowel before **-y**, then keep the **-y** when adding a suffix.

**Examples:** enjoy + **-ed** = enjoyed      play + **-ing** = playing  
buy + **-er** = buyer      joy + **-ful** = joyful

3. When suffixes start with a vowel and are added to the word ending with **-e**, the **-e** is replaced.

**Examples:** care + **-ing** = caring  
noise + **-y** = noisy

The exception to the rule above is that when the word ends in **-ce** or **-ge**, the silent **e** is not replaced if the suffix begins with **a** or **o**.

**Examples:** courage + **-ous** = courageous  
peace + **-able** = peaceable

4. When a word ends in a short vowel sound followed by a single consonant, the last letter of the word will need to be doubled before the suffix is added.

**Examples:** flip + -ed = flipped

mud + -y = muddy

5. When a word has more than one syllable and ends with the letter **l**, you will need to double the **l** when adding the suffix

**Examples:** control + -ed = controlled

compel + -ing = compelling

This rule does not apply to words ending with **-w**, **-x** or **-y**.

**C Fill in the blanks with the correct suffix form of the root word in the brackets.**

- The soldiers fought for their freedom. (free)
- The company had to file for bankruptcy. (bankrupt)
- After she gave birth, the villagers thought that motherhood suited her well. (mother)
- He tried flattery but she wasn't impressed. (flatter)
- He was surprised to learn that piracy was still a problem in that part of the world. (pirate)
- The prince chose courage over cowardice. (brave)
- I take pride in what I do. (proud)
- Why don't you just tell the truth? (true)



## Common Incorrect Phrases

Many phrases in the English language are used incorrectly. The problem might be the way the phrase is used or the way the spellings have changed in the phrase. It can be due to the way the words are pronounced.

Here is a list of some commonly used incorrect phrases.

| Incorrect Phrase | Correct Phrase                                                                |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| all and all      | all in all<br>• considering all the different parts of the situation together |
| day in age       | day and age<br>• now, as opposed to an earlier time                           |
| all for not      | all for naught<br>• all for nothing/all efforts went in vain                  |
| one in the same  | one and the same<br>• same thing/same person                                  |



| Incorrect Phrase     | Correct Phrase                                                                                                                           |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| peaked my interest   | <p>piqued my interest</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• something that rouses interest</li> </ul>                             |
| case and point       | <p>case in point</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• an instance or example that illustrates what is being discussed</li> </ul> |
| another think coming | <p>another thing coming</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• need to reconsider something</li> </ul>                             |
| nerve wrecking       | <p>nerve racking</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• make you feel very nervous and worried</li> </ul>                          |
| I could care less    | <p>I couldn't care less</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• not caring about the issue</li> </ul>                               |
| deep seeded          | <p>deep-seated</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• fixed and strong; difficult to change or to destroy</li> </ul>               |

Here is a list of some commonly misused words.

| Correct Word                                                                                                                                                | What is Used Instead                                                                                                                              |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p>anyway</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• despite something</li> </ul>                                                                         | anyways                                                                                                                                           |
| <p>regardless</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• paying no attention, even if the situation is bad or there are difficulties</li> </ul>           | irregardless                                                                                                                                      |
| <p>et cetera</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• meaning after a list to show that there are other things that you could have mentioned</li> </ul> | exetera                                                                                                                                           |
| <p>not flammable</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• something that cannot catch fire</li> </ul>                                                   | inflammable                                                                                                                                       |
| <p>venomous</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• anything that will poison you if it bites you</li> </ul>                                           | <p>poisonous</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• something that will poison you, but only if you eat it or only when ingested</li> </ul> |

- D** Divide yourselves into groups of five. Discuss and write down five common phrases. Look up in the dictionary if they mean the same as what you thought they did, or if they are spelled the way you think they did.



## Common Indian English Phrases and Words to Avoid

Here are some common Indian English words and phrases that are used incorrectly.

1. Prepone: The opposite of the word postpone is not prepone and it cannot be used as an antonym for the word. Instead, rescheduled should be used.

**Examples:** The meeting was preponed.   
The meeting was rescheduled. 

2. Good name: This phrase is directly translated from Hindi. Just 'What is your name?' would suffice.

**Examples:** So, what's your good name?   
So, what's your name? 

3. Taking lunch: The verb taking is used incorrectly here. Taking lunch would mean that the person is taking their lunch somewhere. Having lunch would be the correct phrase.

**Examples:** Yeah, I'm just taking my lunch.   
Yeah, I'm just having my lunch. 

4. Only: The word only is added to the sentences to make it definite. It is again a direct translation from Hindi.

**Examples:** I'm on my way, only.   
I'm on my way. 

5. Pass out: The phrase means that the person has fainted. Instead of pass out the word graduated should be used.

**Examples:** He passed out in 2020.   
He graduated in 2020. 

6. Given below: The phrase given below is often used when examples or questions are provided, to direct the reader's attention to the examples or questions that follow the statement. Given below is a direct translation from Hindi. Just using below would suffice.

**Examples:** The list is given below.   
Below is the list. 



## Unnecessary Repetition

Certain words in English are used with each other even though they mean the same thing. It is the unnecessary use of more than one word or phrase with the same meaning. When used in writing, it causes superfluous writing. Below is a list of expressions that are commonly misused in English. By definition, these words do not require any other word before or after them. Not even for emphasis, which is often said to be the reason.



## Wrongfully Used Terms

## Explanation

|                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| actual fact                        | Fact by itself means a thing that is known to be true, especially when it can be proved. Using actual in front of fact is unnecessary.                                                                        |
| added bonus                        | A bonus is by definition, something added, so the word <b>added</b> is not needed.                                                                                                                            |
| ATM machine                        | The letter <b>m</b> in ATM already stands for machine. Use ATM on its own or the entire word, automated teller machine.                                                                                       |
| blatantly obvious                  | Things that are blatant are obvious so, using the word <b>obvious</b> here is not required.                                                                                                                   |
| empty space                        | The word, space, already means an unoccupied area, so there is no point in using the word <b>empty</b> .                                                                                                      |
| false pretence and false pretences | Pretences are by definition false. The word <b>false</b> here is unnecessary.                                                                                                                                 |
| repay back                         | The word, repay, by definition, means to pay back the money that you have borrowed from somebody. Repay back as a phrase is incorrect. It should either be <b>repay</b> or <b>pay back</b> .                  |
| repeat again                       | The word, repeat, means to say or write something again or more than once, so the word again should not be used with it.                                                                                      |
| return back                        | The word, return, means to come or go back from one place to another. Use of the word <b>back here</b> is incorrect.                                                                                          |
| revert back                        | Revert by itself means replying; the use of the word <b>back</b> with it is incorrect. By this means, the phrase reply back is also incorrect. It should just be a reply.                                     |
| brief moment                       | A moment is brief, so the use of a brief is not necessary. The same is the case with a brief summary. The use of <b>summary</b> and <b>moment</b> would suffice.                                              |
| circulate around                   | If a story, an idea, information, etc. circulates or if you circulate it, it spreads or is passed from one person to another. By definition, the use of the word <b>around</b> with circulate is unnecessary. |
| close proximity                    | To be in proximity to something is to be close to it. Instead, just proximity should be used.                                                                                                                 |
| collaborate together               | The verb collaborate already implies togetherness since there is no way to collaborate if you're on your own. So, the use of <b>together</b> is unnecessary.                                                  |



## Wrongfully Used Terms

## Explanation

|                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| exact same                                  | The meaning of the word <b>same</b> in the dictionary is 'exactly the one or ones referred to or mentioned; not different'. Using <b>exact</b> with it is not required.                            |
| two equal halves                            | Half by itself means that something is divided into two equal parts. So, using <b>two equal</b> is unnecessary.                                                                                    |
| cancel out                                  | Cancel means to decide that something that has been arranged will not take place. Use of the word <b>out</b> here is not required.                                                                 |
| free gift                                   | A gift is free. The word <b>free</b> is unnecessary.                                                                                                                                               |
| unexpected surprise                         | A surprise is unexpected, so use of the word <b>unexpected</b> is unnecessary.                                                                                                                     |
| using am with morning                       | If a.m. is used, then using the word <b>morning</b> is not required. Just writing, 'tomorrow morning at 9,' and not 'tomorrow morning at 9 <b>am</b> ,' would be enough. Same is the case with pm. |
| total destruction                           | The meaning of destruction is 'the act of destroying something; the process of being destroyed'. Here, use of the word <b>total</b> is not required.                                               |
| temper tantrum                              | Tantrum in itself is temperamental. Therefore, the word <b>temper</b> is unnecessary.                                                                                                              |
| general public                              | The meaning of public is ordinary; using <b>general</b> with it is unnecessary.                                                                                                                    |
| absolutely certain/<br>essential/guaranteed | The words certain, essential and guaranteed are absolute in nature. Using the word <b>absolute</b> with it is unnecessary.                                                                         |
| first and foremost                          | Foremost itself means the first position                                                                                                                                                           |

**E** Find five other unnecessary repetitive phrases and write them in the blanks provided. Also, make a sentence with the correct word or phrase.

1. \_\_\_\_\_
2. \_\_\_\_\_
3. \_\_\_\_\_
4. \_\_\_\_\_
5. \_\_\_\_\_